

after a coup in 1997 and the country's poor human rights record. China became Cambodia's top creditor country, but, this year, Beijing has not approved any new loans. Even the Chinese have discovered that their infrastructural projects in Cambodia have not yielded expected results. According to a December 18 Reuters report, China accounts for more than a third of the country's $11.6 billion debt stock—and the Cambodians are now turning to the World Bank and Japan to bail them out, and for loans on more favourable terms than those from China.

In Europe, Montenegro took a $1 billion loan from China in 2014 to build a new highway. But the project remains unfinished, and the debt it incurred amounts to more than a third of the poor south European country's annual budget. The European Union refused to bail out Montenegro of its loans from China, but a group of American and European banks saved the country from bankruptcy as they stepped in to help restructure the financing.

While Portugal has quietly withdrawn from the BRI, Italy left it altogether and both countries are now reassessing their overall relationship with China. Hungary, the first European country to sign up to the BRI, has benefited from investment in the country's infrastructure. But the bill for a Hungary-Serbia railway project, which is scheduled to be completed in 2025, is a staggering 3.8 billion Euros, or nearly $4 billion—money that an already cash-starved Hungary cannot possibly afford to pay back within the foreseeable future.

Greece is often cited as the BRI's European success story. Under BRI schemes, the Chinese state-owned shipping firm COSCO now owns a 67 per cent share of the port of Piraeus, which has led to rapid increase in container volumes. The port is now one of the busiest in Europe. But it is also the only one where the company prohibits workers from forming any sort of collective representation. COSCO's refusal to engage in any kind of public consultation or meet with civil society representatives has alienated the local community.

A major shortcoming in the actual implementation of Xi's BRI is that there is no central governmental body that oversees the projects, nor is it clear which ministry or ministries are responsible for what. As Yuen Yuen Ang, a professor of political science at the Centre for Chinese Studies at Michigan University, argues, the BRI bears the hallmark of a communist-style mass campaign, which is "typical in China, where the central government often issues broad directives and expects lower-ranking officials to figure out how to fulfil them". But it is highly unlikely that Beijing will change the way it conducts business—and that means that 2025 will be a year of uncertainty when it comes to China's global ambitions. ■

A MAJOR SHORTCOMING IN THE IMPLEMENTATION OF XI'S BELT AND ROAD INITIATIVE IS THAT **THERE IS NO CENTRAL GOVERNMENTAL BODY THAT OVERSEES THE PROJECTS,** OR CLARITY ON WHICH MINISTRY IS RESPONSIBLE

Bertil Lintner *is a journalist, strategic consultant and author of, among other books,* China's India War *and* The Costliest Pearl: China's Struggle for India's Ocean